FREE PRINTABLE

What Cleans What

Vinegar, hydrogen peroxide and Listerine: every job each one does, with the dilution and the timing, the surfaces to keep it off, and what never to mix.

Three bottles most homes already own. Match the job to the chemistry: acid for scale, oxygen for organic stains and mildew, alcohol and oils for odor and quick disinfecting.

PLAIN WHITE DISTILLED VINEGAR, 5 PERCENT

Vinegar

USE IT FOR

Showerhead scale	Bag of undiluted vinegar over the head, overnight (8 hours). Plated or bronze finishes: 30 minutes, repeat another night.
Glass and mirrors	Equal parts vinegar and warm water. Spray the cloth, wipe one direction, buff dry. One drop of dish soap for a greasy window.
Faucet scale	Vinegar soaked paper towel draped over it, 15 minutes and no longer. Aerator: 30 minutes in a shot glass.
Microwave	1 cup vinegar, 1 cup water, a toothpick in the bowl, 3 minutes on high, door shut 2 more, wipe.
Smelly drain	1/2 cup baking soda, then 1 cup vinegar warmed 30 seconds, 10 minutes, flush with a kettle of boiling water (hot tap water for old PVC).
Mug stains	Equal parts vinegar and warm water for one hour. Stubborn ring: loose baking soda paste, rub gently.
Dishwasher	A cup of vinegar upright on the top rack, hot empty cycle, monthly, after rinsing the filter.

KEEP IT OFF

Natural stone (marble, granite, travertine, limestone), cast iron, raw aluminum, waxed or oiled wood, anti glare coatings, and anything plated or cheap chrome for longer than 15 minutes.

HONEST LIMIT

Not a reliable disinfectant. For raw meat surfaces use a product labelled as a sanitizer.

3 PERCENT, THE BROWN DRUGSTORE BOTTLE

Hydrogen peroxide

USE IT FOR

Grout	Paste of about 3 tablespoons baking soda to 1 of peroxide, 30 to 60 minutes, stiff brush, rinse. Mist if it goes chalky.
Counters after raw meat	Clean with soap first, then mist and keep it wet for the contact time on the label.
Fresh blood	Cold rinse from the back, peroxide on the stain, let it fizz, cold rinse, launder. No heat until it is gone.
Yellow underarms, whites only	Soak the area 3 to 5 minutes. Old marks: baking soda paste first, up to 30 minutes.
Shower liner hem	Undiluted along the hem and seams, 10 to 15 minutes, wipe or rinse.
Baked on glass dishes	Layer of baking soda, peroxide sprayed over it, an hour or overnight, plastic scraper.
Sponges, holders, lids	Soak 10 to 15 minutes in straight peroxide, rinse, dry fully.
Bin, fridge, toilet	Spray the empty bin 5 to 10 minutes. Mist fridge shelves and wipe. Half a cup under the toilet rim, 20 to 30 minutes.
Whites in the wash	About half a cup in the drum with the detergent, warm wash.

KEEP IT OFF

Natural stone, unsealed wood floors, silk and wool, colored fabric you have not tested on a seam, and metal that can rust (dry it).

HONEST LIMIT

Does not cut grease or remove limescale. Test the bottle: no fizz on a used sponge means it has turned to water.

ORIGINAL AMBER ONLY, NOT BLUE OR WHITENING

Listerine

USE IT FOR

All purpose spray	Equal parts amber Listerine and warm water. Sealed laminate, glazed tile, glass, stainless, tested painted trim. Shake before each use.
Trash can	Undiluted around the empty can, 5 minutes, then the new bag. Coat the bottom corners.
Washing machine smell	1 cup straight into the drum, hottest empty cycle. Wipe the gasket fold first.
Toothbrush holder	Fill with undiluted, 10 minutes, old toothbrush in the crevices, rinse, dry.
Stove knobs	Pull them off, 15 minutes in a bowl of Listerine, soft brush, dry fully. Wipe the rings under them.
Cutting boards	Wash with soap first, spray, 2 minutes, rinse well. A finishing rinse, not a cleaner.
Toilet	Half a cup, 30 minutes, scrub under the rim. A freshener, not a descaler.
Handles and switches	Damp cloth with the diluted spray, a moment of contact, never sprayed on directly.

KEEP IT OFF

Unsealed stone, raw wood, lacquered wood. Store brand amber mouthwash works the same for half the price.

HONEST LIMIT

Flammable at full strength, so burners off and cool. Eucalyptol and thymol are toxic to cats.

NEVER MIX

One product at a time, rinse between

Vinegar + bleach	Chlorine gas.
Vinegar + peroxide in one bottle	Peracetic acid, which burns eyes, skin and airways. One, rinse, then the other is fine.
Vinegar + ammonia or ammonia glass cleaner	Irritating fumes, and both stop working.
Peroxide + bleach or ammonia	Same session counts, including bleach bowl cleaners and blue tank tablets.
Listerine + bleach	Genuinely dangerous. Never in the same sitting.

BEFORE ANY NEW SURFACE

The thirty second test

1. One drop on a hidden corner, wait 30 seconds.
2. Fizzing, foaming or a dull ring means stone or a coating that will not take it. Use a pH neutral cleaner there.
3. Peroxide bleaches: test colored fabric on an inside seam first.
4. Label every bottle with what is in it and the date. A clear bottle of peroxide looks exactly like water.